Present & Past Infinitive

The infinitives are the natural and unconjugated form of the verb. For example: parler = to speak, faire = to do, prendre = to take etc.

Usages of Present Infinitive

As a Secondary Verb

Français	English
Je peux **prendre** ta photo si tu veux.	I can take your photo if you want.
Il veut **acheter** une nouvelle voiture.	He wants to buy a new car.
Elle va t'**appeler** demain.	She is going to call you tomorrow.
J'espère **me marier** un jour.	I hope to get married one day.
Elle n'a pas envie de **manger**.	She doesn't feel like eating.

Infinitive as a Subject

The infinitive can be used as the subject of a verb in a sentence.

Français	English
Être proche de la nature est important.	Being close to nature is important.
Nager est bon pour la santé.	Swimming is good for your health.
Voir, c'est croire.	Seeing is believing.
Savoir, c'est pouvoir.	Knowledge is power.
Apprendre le japonais n'est pas facile.	Learning Japanese isn't easy.

For General Instructions (Impersonal Orders)

The infinitive is also used for general instructions, prescriptions, public notices, and proverbs (where the imperative is often used in English).

Français	English
Ne pas jeter les ordures ici.	Do not litter here.
Lire attentivement les instructions.	Read the instructions attentively.

Mettre toujours la ceinture de sécurité.	Always put the seatbelt on.
Saisir la journée, les gars !	Seize the day, boys!
Porter un masque.	Wear a mask.

After Verbs of Perception

The infinitive is used after verbs of perception in French (whereas the present participle is used in such cases in English). The following verbs indicate a perception or sensation:

apercevoir - to catch a glimpse of | **écouter** - to listen to | **entendre** - to hear
regarder - to watch | **sentir** - to feel/ to smell | **voir** - to see

Français	English
J'ai **vu** le bus **partir** sans moi.	I saw the bus leave without me.
Elle a **entendu** leur fils **crier.**	She heard their son shout.
J'ai **senti** le sol **trembler**.	I felt the ground shaking.
J'**aperçois** un arbre **tomber.**	I am catching a glimpse of a falling tree.
J'**entends** les étudiants **arriver.**	I hear the students arriving.
Je **sens** le vent **souffler.**	I feel the wind blowing.
Nous **sentons** la forêt **brûler**.	We smell the forest burning.

Interrogative Infinitive

As the title suggests, infinitives can also be used as it is to ask questions. Here the question is in generic sense hence no subject, and we use infinitives instead of conjugated verbs.

Français	English
Comment lui **expliquer** ce phénomène ?	How to explain this phenomenon to her?
Que/Quoi **faire** lorsque quelqu'un s'évanouit ?	What to do when someone faints?
Que/Quoi **dire ?**	What to say ?
Où **aller ?**	Where to go?
Quelle couleur **choisir ?**	Which color to choose?

" Que " and " quoi " can be used interchangeably. But **"que"** is more formal/ literary.

After the expression Avant de

The present infinitive can be used after the expression “avant de” (before).

Français	English
Il s’est fait vacciner **avant de partir** en vacances**.**	He got vaccinated before going on a vacation.
Je bois toujours une tasse de café **avant de commence**r mon travail.	I always drink a cup of coffee before starting my work.
Lavez-vous toujours les mains **avant de manger**.	Always wash your hands before eating.
Vous devriez lire le contrat **avant de signer**.	You should read the contract before signing.
Réfléchissez bien **avant de prendre** la décision.	Think well before taking the decision.

Instructions in Cookbooks and Manuals

The present infinitive was often used in professional cookbooks and other instruction manuals, although nowadays, the imperative is preferred.

Français	English
Éplucher trois carottes.	Peel three carrots.
Écraser les pommes de terre.	Mash the potatoes.
Ajouter les herbes.	Add the herbs.
Hacher les champignons.	Chop the mushrooms.
Faire bouillir deux tasses d’eau.	Boil two cups of water.

Faire + Verb (To make the Intransitive Verbs Transitive)

L’eau bout. - The water is boiling (no object since it is intransitive)
Je fais bouillir de l’eau. - I’m boiling some water. (this is now transitive)
Faire Sauter (stir-fry, toss)

Français	English
Ajouter les champignons et faire sauter.	Add the mushrooms and stir-fry.

Faire Cuire (bake)

Français	English
Faire cuire le gâteau au four à 180 degrés.	Bake the cake in the oven at 180 degrees.

Faire Chauffer (warm, heat)

Français	English
Faire chauffer l'huile avant de faire sauter les ingrédients.	Heat the oil before tossing the ingredients

Faire Frire (deep-fry)

Français	English
Faire frire les pommes de terre pour créer des frites comme McDonald's.	Deep fry the potatoes to make fries like McDonald's.

The Past Infinitive

When one thing happens before another, you can use the French past infinitive to talk about the earlier action. It is used to describe anteriority.
It is formed with the infinitive of avoir or être and the past participle of the main verb.

Note: With être as auxiliary, the past participle of the past infinitive agrees with the subject of the sentence.)

Français	English
Elle regrette **d'être partie** trop tard.	She regrets leaving too late.
Je suis très fier de **ne jamais avoir raté** un vol.	I am very proud of never having missed a flight.
Je suis content d'**avoir terminé** mon travail tôt.	I am happy, having finished my work early.

Usage: To Express Gratitude

Français	English
Je vous remercie de m'**avoir aidé**.	I thank you for having helped me.
Merci d'**avoir fait** ce gâteau, il était délicieux.	Thanks for making this cake, it was delicious.
Mes amis, merci à tous d'**être venus**.	My friends, thank you all for coming.
J'ai remercié Lucas de m'**avoir raccompagné(e)** hier.	I thanked Lucas for giving me a ride home yesterday.

Usage: After Preposition “après”

One common occurrence of the past infinitive is after the preposition après (after).

Français	English
Je parlerai avec vous **après avoir déjeuné.**	I will speak with you after having eaten lunch.
Elle va dormir **après avoir fini** ses devoirs.	She is going to bed after having finished her homework.
Après avoir donné du sang, je suis parti.	After having given blood, I left.
Un mois **après être tombé** malade, je me suis finalement remis.	One month after having fallen sick, I finally recovered.
Il s’est rendu compte qu’il avait oublié son portefeuille **après être parti**.	He realised he'd forgotten his wallet after having left.

Negation of the Infinitive

Since a verb in the infinitive mood is not conjugated, the negation keywords (ne... pas and other forms) do not surround the verb but rather precede it.

Français	English
Je préfère **ne pas voyager** en bus.	I prefer not to travel by bus.
Ma mère m’a dit **de ne jamais parler** avec des étrangers.	My mother told me not to ever speak with strangers.
Essayez **de ne pas brûler** la maison quand vous cuisinez.	Try not to burn the house when you’re cooking.
Parfois, il vaut mieux **ne rien dire**.	Sometimes, it is better not to say anything.
J'espère **ne pas faire** d'erreurs.	I hope not to make a mistake.
Ma mère m'a dit de **ne pas le faire.** (*Épouser Ivanka)	My mother told me not to do it
Le professeur conseille de ne pas fumer.	The teacher advises not to smoke.